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The Ultimate Guide to Reducing File Size in Excel

BY CHRIS · JULY 30, 2016

You've probably encountered them many times before: really large files in Microsoft Excel.

And everything about them is **terrible**.

They're difficult to email to colleagues or customers, they take too long to open, and take forever to update or change formulas every time you change a value.

Which means you're sitting in front of some kind of loading bar, **wasting your time** when you could be getting back to completing your work.

So how do these files get so big and unworkable? If you're sharing these files with colleagues, classmates or friends, you'll probably never find out.

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Fortunately, there are a wide range of ways to fix this within Excel itself.

In this post, you can find all of the best tips to help you manage these large and

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- **saving calculation time**, and
- **optimising formulas**.

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And now you’re all set!

Directly reduce file size

In this section are the easy and straightforward options to cut down on file size. If you don’t want to alter the contents of the workbook, try these options first.

1. Remove “blank space” in your sheets

This is definitely the most common source of large Excel file sizes, and fortunately one of the easiest to fix.

Excel has a “used range” for every sheet in your workbook. **The larger this is, the bigger the file size becomes.**

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file, it will increase to represent the rightmost column and furthest row that you've edited or formatted.

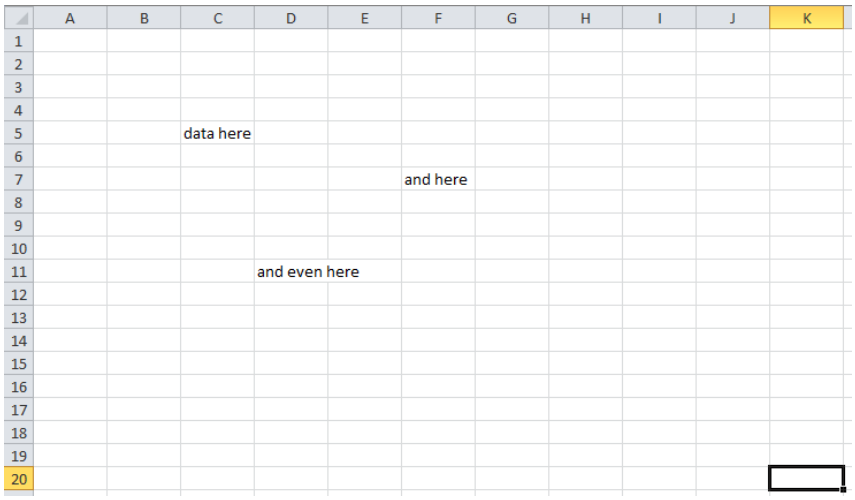
Especially in older files, even if cells are blank and have no formatting, Excel may be treating them inside the used range, leading to a larger file size for no reason.

Example of the "used range" in Excel

If you press **Ctrl + End** on any sheet in your Excel file, you can see what the "last used cell" is. If that shortcut takes you many rows (or columns) past the end of your data, it means that all of those cells are increasing the file size for no reason.

Here's an example. I've got data that goes until column F and row 11, so I should expect that the used range goes until cell F11 (even if nothing is in that specific cell).

But when I press Ctrl + End, this happens:



(Note: to get this result, I simply entered a value in cell K20 then deleted it.)

How to Fix the "Used Range" in Excel

To shrink the used range to the cells you're using, simply delete the extra blank rows or columns:

1. Select the first blank row (or column). You can easily do this via shortcuts by pressing **Shift + Space** for the current row, or **Ctrl + Space** for the current column.
2. Press **Ctrl + Shift + Arrow Down** (or Arrow Right) to go to the very bottom or very right of the Excel sheet.
3. Right-click and select Delete. Do **NOT** simply press the Delete button – it won't have the same effect, all it will do is clear the contents of the cells!

In older versions of Excel, you'll need to save the file after deleting the unnecessary rows and columns. If you press Ctrl + End again, the last used cell should now be next to the cells you just deleted.

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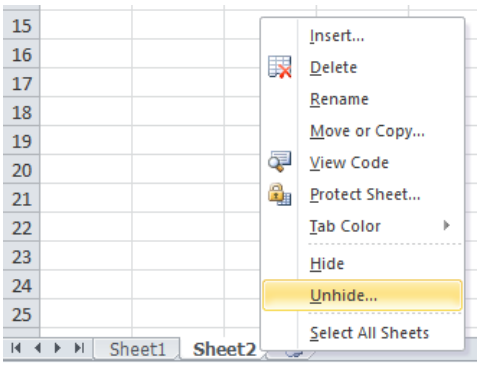
hidden sheets

If you have received an Excel file from someone else, they may have hidden some additional sheets as part of the file, but hidden them for some reason.

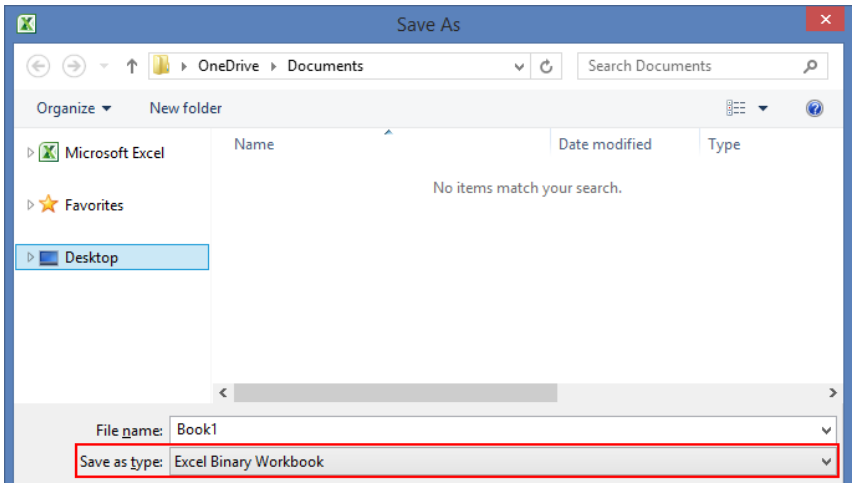
You can reduce the file size of your Excel workbook by unhiding all sheets, and checking if you still require that data or not.



3. Save your files in binary format (.xlsb)

I've hidden the best way to reduce file size down at #3.

If you have an Excel file with lots of raw data and lots of formulas, go and **save it in the Excel binary format (.xlsb)**.



Any Macros and VBA will still be retained in this format, so you don't have to worry about loss of functionality.

Most files will get a reduction in file size of roughly 50% by saving it in the .xlsb format, but this will vary depending on what kind of data is in the file.

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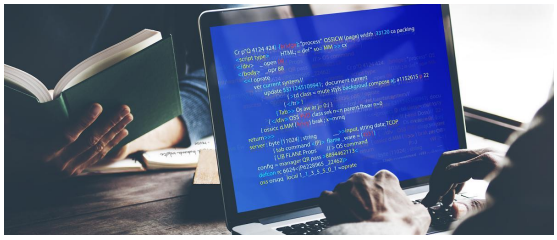

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Sometimes you can reduce files down to 20% of their original file size!

4. Remove formatting on raw data

If your raw data contains formatting, then it's going to increase the file size in Excel.

Of course, your job or assignment may require the data to be presented in a specific way – but if it will never be viewed directly and only needs to be used for calculation purposes, then remove as much formatting as possible.

I can think of a few ex-bosses of mine who would hate me if I removed any formatting from files that we gave to our clients, but if it's an internal working file, then avoid formatting it just to make it look pretty for you. Be careful of using the Clear Formats options to do this – you will also strip out any date or currency formats from data which can be confusing (eg: Jan 1st 2016 will change to '42370'). Formatting such as borders, highlighting and unique fonts are good examples to remove.

5. Double check Conditional Formatting ranges

Conditional Formatting is a fantastic way to visually compare any changes in numbers in data ranges, but it can come at a hefty price – a bloated Excel file!

One mistake some Excel users make is to apply formatting to an entire sheet, or an entire group of rows or columns.

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Go to Conditional Formatting > Manage Rules and check the cell range of each of the rules. If the applied range is larger than what you need, then consider limiting it to only the required data range.

> *Want more formatting shortcuts? Check out this Excel Shortcut Roundup*

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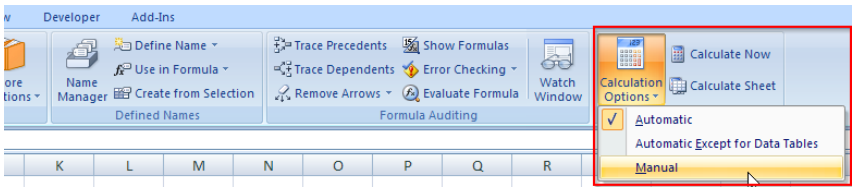
If you're dealing with a large file in Excel, then you'll eventually end up with a file that with lots of formulas that recalculate as you make changes.

For most workbooks, the file size and number of calculations will be so small that you'll never notice that Excel recalculates any time you update a value that it depends on. But, when you have hundreds of thousands of formulas the time will start to add up, which means you can often be sitting around twiddling your thumbs for minutes at a time.

1. Disable automatic formula calculation

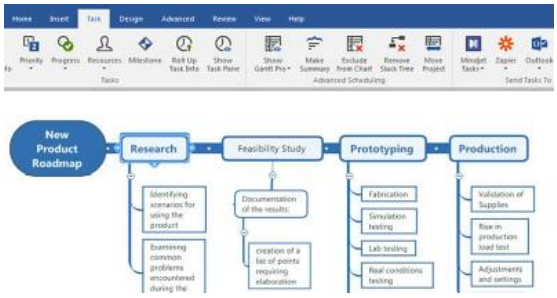
If formula calculation is slowing down your work, then go ahead and disable it.

A large number of Excel users don't even know this option is available – you can find it in the Formulas tab in the Excel ribbon, towards the end:



While formula calculation is set to Manual, you can force a recalculation of the entire workbook by pressing the **F9** key. If you only want to recalculate one sheet, then **Shift + F9** will calculate the currently selected sheet.

Now, you might notice some strange behaviour when Manual is selected. If you edit a cell containing a formula and press Enter, that formula will calculate as usual. If you then copy that formula to other cells, the previous result will be displayed (temporarily!) until you hit the F9 key. Don't worry about it, just keep working as normal and once you press the F9 key (or change the Calculation option back to Automatic) the sheet will update completely.



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And if you want a single formula to be updated, you can edit the cell (F2), hit Enter, and that formula will calculate.

One final note on this point: always make sure to change calculation back to Automatic when you're finished working on a file, or when you're about to send

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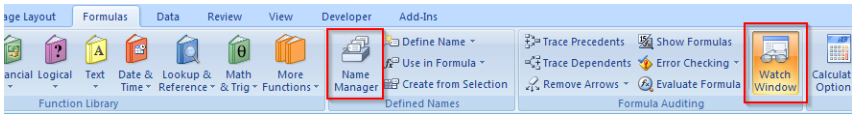
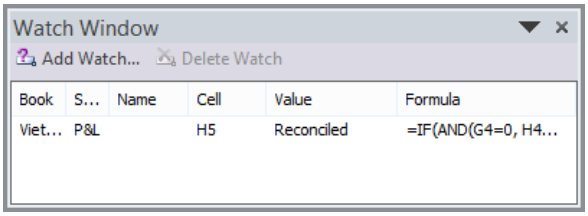
check on specific cells

Also in the Formulas menu, you can click on the **Watch Window** option to open up a small dialog box which appears in front of your Excel workbook.



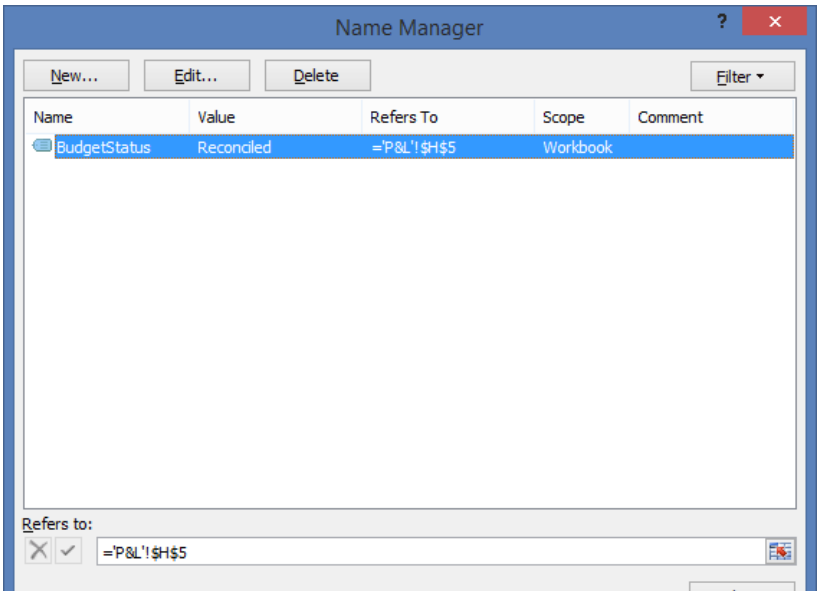
The Watch Window contains a list of cells that you specifically want to keep an eye on. For example, you might be working on a detailed budget which has workings across multiple sheets. All of those sheets feed values into a high-level budget summary sheet, and you want to know the final profit or loss while working on other sheets.

In the Watch Window, click on the Add Watch button and select the cell you want to keep a close eye on. The value will always be visible, regardless of which sheet is active.



If you want to populate the Name field, follow these steps:

1. Select the **Name Manager** in the Formula menu.
2. Select New, and type whatever reference you like in the Name field.
3. Make sure the "Refers to:" box is pointed to the cell you're using in the Watch Window.
4. Click OK and close the Name Manager.



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Apart from shrinking file size directly, you can use the below tips to optimise your Excel formulas so they run faster.

1. Avoid using volatile formulas

Seven functions in Excel are known as **volatile** – ie, they calculate every time **any cell** is updated in the workbook.

These seven functions are RAND(), NOW(), TODAY(), OFFSET(), CELL(), INDIRECT() and INFO(). Microsoft lists them here on their help page.

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Minimising the use of these functions in your workbook will cut down on unnecessary calculation time.

2. Use PivotTables or Excel Tables

It may seem slightly counter-intuitive, but using PivotTables instead of a series of formulas is a very effective way to show your results. PivotTables are designed by Microsoft to operate efficiently in Excel, so use them if it makes sense!

Similarly, putting your data in a Table is also very efficient. Any formulas (calculated fields) within the Table contribute less to file size compared to a series of formulas on a normal data range.

> *Want to learn more about Excel Tables? Read the 9 (+1) Benefits of Excel Tables here.*

3. Avoid referencing entire rows or columns

I am especially guilty of this – using a SUMIF() or VLOOKUP() function that asks Excel to look up an entire column, even if my data is only a few hundred rows. So instead of having:

```
=SUMIF(A:A, $C4, B:B)
```

You should have:

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This way, Excel will only search the data range you specify – not all 1,048,576 rows.

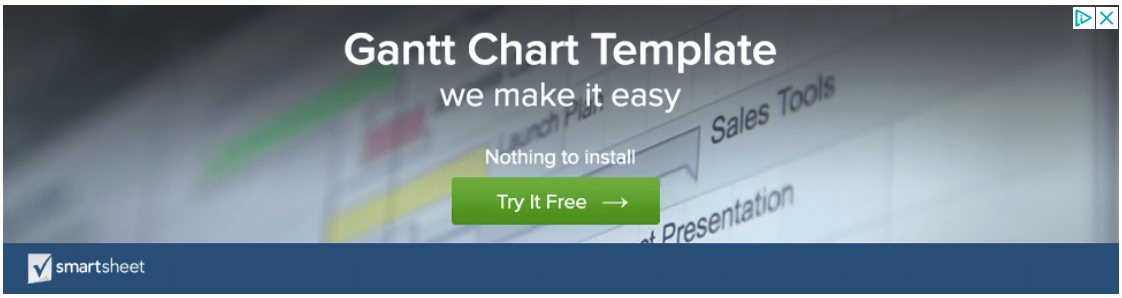
4. Avoid repeated calculations

For this tip, you want to reduce the number of cell references that your formulas have. It's not something that most Excel users will think about, but it's worthwhile if you're planning on some serious number crunching.

Let's use a really basic example:

Say you have a formula which contains "=$D$5+$E$5", and you copy that formula to one hundred cells. In this case, the total number of cell references is two hundred, despite the number of unique cells only being two.

But if F5 has a formula which is =D5+E5, and you update those one hundred cells to refer to cell F5, then you have halved the number of cell references. Excel only has to calculate D5+E5 one time, instead of one hundred times.



So if you have a large number of formulas that perform the same calculation, consider breaking them up in your sheet to speed up the calculation.

5. Sort your data when using formulas that look up values

When you browse through an alphabetised filing cabinet, it's fairly quick to find what you want (provided the items in the cabinet are in order)!

The same idea applies to Microsoft Excel.

If you're using VLOOKUP(), INDEX(), MATCH(), SUMIF(), or any other Excel function which looks for a specific value, your sheet will calculate much quicker if the data you're searching in is already sorted.

> *Learn more about Excel formulas **here**.*

Bonus option: changing the file extension

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method to reduce file size.

Because of the way .xls/.xlsx files are stored, you can treat them as .zip files and rename them without any issues.

Now I'm not a huge fan of this process, but it does appear to work!

Here's the process:

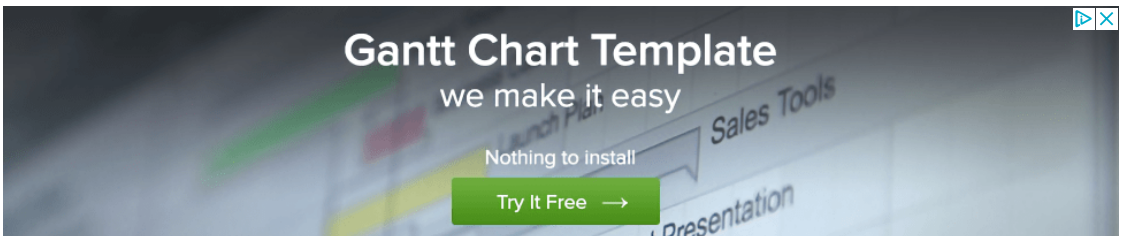
1. Navigate to your file in Windows Explorer, and change the filename from .xls/.xlsx to .zip.
2. Unzip the file, just like you would with any other .zip file. You should get a few folders and an XML file:

3. Zip up the files that were just extracted into a new .zip file.
4. Change the filename back to the original .xls/.xlsx file extension.

And now you're all set!

So there you have it. You now have plenty of options to ensure you're working on smaller, more manageable Excel files.

And even better, your files should spend less time to open, and formulas should take less time to calculate!



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down on file size? Let us know in the comments!

Tags: calculation file formats file size formulas

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Lynn Sandy May 18, 2017 at 4:29 pm

Hi, thanks for your tips above. The method that i found most use useful is to save the Excel Sheet as a Text (tab delimited), close it. Open a new Excel Sheet, navigate to Data, Get External Data, From Text and import the text file back into excel. took me less than a minute to get the data back in Excel format.

Reply

Chris May 18, 2017 at 4:58 pm

Hi Lynn, that's really interesting. As a percentage, approximately how much would the file size shrink after you import the data back into Excel?

Chris

Reply

Gregg London September 28, 2017 at 7:23 am

I found this to be of significant benefit: Rename the Original File, Create a new Excel File, Copy the Contents of the Renamed Original File, then Paste (as Values – not a the usual Control V) the Copied Data into the new File. In one of

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9.5MB to 2.4MB.

Reply

Chris September 28, 2017 at 1:03 pm

That's really interesting Gregg, thanks for sharing!

Out of curiosity, did your data have a lot of formatting, borders or highlighting? That information may have been contributing to the initial large file size.

Reply

karl August 10, 2017 at 3:31 am

Excellent advice

How to Fix the "Used Range" in Excel: Right click, delete

Reply

ashwin ramesh September 14, 2017 at 11:37 am

Hi Chris,

I have a 3 sheets containing the inquiry, order, billing details of customers for months which runs into 1000 rows and 30 – 40 columns. I have this data in tables. The file size is 11 mb due to pivot tables and other formulae. How can i reduce the file size without affecting the formulae. I tried saving the file in binary format but file reduced to 9 mb. any tricks which can help??

Reply

Chris September 19, 2017 at 5:16 am

Hi Ashwin,

If you need the formulas then there aren't too many options left. If there are specific columns of data that you don't need, you might want to consider deleting those columns but it won't reduce the file size too much.

Otherwise, you might want to consider splitting the data and the PivotTables into separate Excel files. The PivotTables can still refer to data that is in another file, but you will need to have both files open to make it update.

Let me know how you go!

Chris

Reply

MN September 15, 2017 at 3:42 pm

Very handy! Saving to binary reduced my file size from 8991KB to 2771 KB. Thanks!

Reply

Andrew Weaver October 11, 2017 at 5:44 pm

If I press Ctrl and End, I get taken to cell T1048432. If I delete the rows from the bottom of my data (row 84) down to row 1,048,432 and press Ctrl and End again, I still end up

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Reply

Chris October 12, 2017 at 2:19 am

Hi Andrew, try saving the file after you delete the relevant data. That should fix your problem!

Chris

Reply

Claire December 1, 2017 at 3:47 am

You have to clear content instead of delete when you right-click.

Reply

CurtisA January 17, 2018 at 3:30 am

Very helpful comment, thank you Claire!

Doing this on one tab reduced my file size from ~30MB to about 4MB.

Reply

Katherine November 6, 2018 at 4:07 am

For some reason, this is not working for me…I have Office 365 (Microsoft Office 2016) on a 64bit desktop. I have a 44 MB Application that I am trying to reduce in size. I have selected the bottom portion of a worksheets, as described here. At first I deleted, then I cleared contents, then I cleared all… My blank cell range keeps enlarging!!! It started at row 3130 and I am now at row 9184. I previously had a macro that was "clearing a range" (the range that I was working with…I was only doing this to make sure that ALL blank cells were cleared out in order to reduce the size of my app) and a subroutine to delete all pictures and return the "cursor" to cell "A1". –> For some reason, I am heading in the wrong direction. It seems like, if I "touch" a cell (even to clear it), I am making my Application larger. What can I do?

Reply

Chris November 6, 2018 at 5:22 am

Hi Katherine, I'm wondering if your macro script is accidentally adding some size to the file because just "touching" a cell shouldn't increase any file size. If you want, you can email the macro VBA code to chris@excelefficiency.com and I can see if there's an errant piece of code that isn't working as it should?

Chris

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Reply

Chris2 January 5, 2018 at 2:03 am

Thanks very much!

I applied the deleting unnecessary columns and removing unnecessary conditional formatting hints, and reduced an xlsx file which was > 12 MB to < 7 MB

Reply

Chris January 5, 2018 at 6:16 am

Not a problem!

Reply

Laura March 9, 2018 at 3:13 am

Very useful! Thanks!

Reply

Dileep March 18, 2018 at 2:17 pm

My excel work book file was 151 MB. after removing unwanted files (steps for removal : (1) filtered out unwanted records 2) displayed data records not needed 3) select all, right mouse click and Delete – to delete all records), it came to 131 MB.

Now I saved as Exce; 97-2003 format, from Excel Work Book – surprise!! it is now 39 MB.

Winzipped the file – it is now 12 MB, I can send in mail to all (upto 15 MB size supported).

Reply

Chris March 18, 2018 at 7:56 pm

That's excellent Dileep! A great combination of methods to get the file size down. I wonder what the size would be if you saved the Excel Workbook as a binary file (.xlsb)…

Chris

Reply

Andi March 27, 2018 at 8:58 pm

This is excellent! I had a file size of 11mb reduced to 47kb just by doing the Ctl+end and deleting the extra rows/columns! Delighted.

Reply

Chris March 28, 2018 at 5:11 am

Fantastic! Great to hear.

Chris

Reply

Nicolas April 9, 2018 at 10:49 pm

Hello

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Why?

Reply

Chris April 13, 2018 at 8:25 am

Hi Nicolas,

What version of Microsoft Excel are you using? This method may not work on older versions.

Thanks,

Chris

Reply

Rohit May 11, 2018 at 5:15 pm

Good Information about how to Reducing File Size in Excel

Reply

Tim May 19, 2018 at 4:32 am

Thanks for the article. Great advice. I'd also recommend taking a look at your "Name Manager" under the Formulas ribbon. If you use named ranges and duplicate a tab, the named range also duplicates, but only for that worksheet rather than the whole workbook. It can also get messy when using legacy files or tailoring an existing file that may have old name references in it. I've cleared out 5+MB from files before just by deleting irrelevant named ranges.

Reply

Annie June 16, 2018 at 3:48 am

Thanks so much! The ctrl + end command just helped me remove 10MB of unnecessary space from my file! It was a file I received from a coworker, so I had no idea why it was so large or how to fix it. 🙂

Reply

Chris June 16, 2018 at 7:46 am

Not a problem Annie!

Reply

Carin Sweerman July 11, 2018 at 1:23 am

Thank you! I just cut & paste some data from an existing complicated worksheet (1,028 kb) into a new worksheet, and for some reason, it ended up being over 19,000 kb! Drove me nuts; kept freezing and just wouldn't let me work with it. Came across your page here, did the Ctrl Shift & end function and saw all the extra space that somehow got into my new worksheet. After I right clicked, deleted and saved, brought my new sheet down to 28 kb 🙂 Learned something new today!

Reply

Chris July 11, 2018 at 6:12 am

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Nobel July 25, 2018 at 2:26 am

Thank u for helpful tips.

Reply

Hoang August 3, 2018 at 2:48 pm

Thank you. The 1st tip is useful . The most common mistake but I didn't know it . Sad.

Reply

Pauline August 14, 2018 at 3:27 am

Hi.

I used to be able to use the ctrl shift down arrow option to go to the bottom of the sheet in order to delete extra rows and ctrl shift right arrow to get to the last column and delete them too. Now all of a sudden I can't. The down arrow just takes me to the next row and the right arrow jumps a few columns but never gets to the rightmost column. And ctrl end remains inside of cells that have been background filled, not go to the lowest rightmost used cell. Can anyone say what has happened?

Reply

Chris August 14, 2018 at 6:02 am

Hi Pauline,

I think you've entered 'End Mode'. Try pressing the End button on your keyboard to get out of it. Let me know how you go!

Chris

Reply

Randy September 24, 2018 at 11:31 pm

Thanks for the info. I used it to clean up a spreadsheet that had multiple sheets and had grown to 10.5MB.

After cleaning up, it shrunk to 2.61MB. I have not used binary worksheets, but tried that and file reduced to 1.4MB.

Love finding stuff like this and appreciate you sharing

Reply

Greg September 28, 2018 at 1:34 am

Hi Chris,

thanks for this little collection. i love binary format, i'm using it since a while, it's really useful.

one thing i miss is the use of array formulas. it can take while for excel to recalculate if you have too much of them.

Reply

Somu Marthandam November 13, 2018 at 9:51 pm

Hi Chris, Thanks a lot for your great tips. I used the ctrl+end one and reduced my

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Donovan November 29, 2018 at 12:23 am

Hi Chris,

We often get extremely large Excel files due to the used range. Most of the time I'm able to delete the extra columns and rows without any issues, however occasionally I am presented with an error stating "there isn't enough memory to complete this action…try using less data…increase memory availability, or using 64-bit version of Excel". We are on 64-bit version and the other changes don't help. Do you have any advice for this?

Reply

Chris November 29, 2018 at 5:33 am

Hi Donovan, my first suggestion is to try deleting a handful of rows or columns at a time. Excel might not want to do all of them at once, but breaking it up into 5 or 6 separate delete actions might help!

Reply

Don Buelke January 5, 2019 at 7:20 am

The instructions on how to Fix the "Used Range" in Excel doesn't work for me on Office 365/Windows 10. Selection of the parameters executes as expected, but when I right-click and select delete, the highlighted area just shifts back to the first column selected and all the column headings and lines/boxes are still displayed. I can "Hide" them and they disappear, but is that going to correct the problem caused by too much open range? (Out here in Montana we use cattle guards to limit open ranges, but I couldn't find that option on Excel!)

****

To shrink the used range to the cells you're using, simply delete the extra blank rows or columns:

Select the first blank row (or column). You can easily do this via shortcuts by pressing Shift + Space for the current row, or Ctrl + Space for the current column.

Press Ctrl + Shift + Arrow Down (or Arrow Right) to go to the very bottom or very right of the Excel sheet.

Right-click and select Delete. Do NOT simply press the Delete button – it won't have the same effect, all it will do is clear the contents of the cells!

Reply

Alan January 11, 2019 at 8:03 am

I have a file of about 1 GB containing about 400K rows up tp column CZ. it contains OFFSET formulas alot because I'm going to find max and min of a range of previous cells data after a certain criterion is met. how much the offset volatile formula does affect the slowness?

Is there any alternative solution/function which is not volatile in order to prvide such functionality for me?

It has taken about 12 hours to distibute about 50 cells formulas of row number 2 to

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other above mentioned advices to see wht will happen.

And I'm not sure after finishing the dstibution of the formulas to the end if I can work with this huge file. my system is a mac book pro with windows and SSD Hard drive and 16GB RAM. Any comment to help me to have a workable file afterwrd please?

Reply

Chris January 11, 2019 at 9:22 am

Hi Alan,

Unfortunately OFFSET() is a volatile formula which updates every time a cell is updated in the workbook.

If you need to keep the OFFSET formulas in your workbook, I suggest disabling automatic calculation of formulas (set it to Manual instead). Find that option in the Excel Ribbon by going to Formulas > **Calculation > Calculation Options**.

Thanks,

Chris

Reply

Kevin January 15, 2019 at 5:38 am

I have a spreadsheet that is only using 400 rows and columns to AQ, however using the Ctrl+End takes me to line 1048299, if i Ctrl+Shft+down arrow it won't let me delete as it is too much for the program , at least that is what the error code says.
File size was 244mb, so i saved it to binary and it is now 31mb, how do i remove all those rows?

Reply

Chris January 18, 2019 at 8:25 am

Hi Kevin,

I've come across this a few times.

Try deleting batches of rows, instead of all of them at the same time. Try selecting 50,000 or 100,000 rows and see if that will work.

Thanks,

Chris

Reply

Jeanie K January 19, 2019 at 6:43 am

i have done all of these tips and still my file size wouldn't go down from 122mb! i had one table with no calculations (all pasted as values after my calculations are done). Then i stumbled across Name Manager and saw all the cell names are still stored and copied over from other workbooks, once deleted, i saved and closed it before reopening the file again. went down to 55kb!

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The first suggestion totally worked. I'm not sure why my file had so many unused rows and columns…maybe because I formatted the fill color of entire rows or columns even though they didn't contain data so far out? Anyway, thanks!

Reply

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